

The 30-Minute Used Boat Walkaround

AN ONTARIO BUYER'S INSPECTION GUIDE

What to check, what to ask,
and when to walk away.



FIVE MINUTES BEFORE YOU GO

10 questions that filter wasted drives.

THIRTY MINUTES AT THE BOAT

Time-blocked inspection -- hull, interior, motor, trailer.

GREEN / YELLOW / RED

A simple severity key for every check.

FIELD CHECKLIST

Print it. Take it. Tick the boxes.

QUICK ANSWER

A 30-minute walkaround inspection catches most of the issues that turn cheap used boats into expensive lessons. Check transom flex, gear-oil colour, floor softness, fuel-system age, electrical condition, and outboard compression if you can. Most private-sale used boats hide one or two of these. **Walking away costs nothing.**

Kijiji. Facebook Marketplace. The listing looks clean. The price feels right. The seller says it "runs great." Now you're driving two hours to go look at it.

Most buyers show up without a plan. They like the look of it, take a quick ride, and pull the trigger -- only to find out a month later the transom is rotting and the floor stringers are soft. At that point, the money they "saved" is long gone.

This is the inspection process we'd run ourselves. **Work through it in order. Let the boat make the decision.**

The simple decision key

Throughout this guide, each check gets graded with a three-colour severity scale. Use it to decide whether to keep inspecting, ask more questions, or leave.

GREEN	YELLOW	RED
Normal used-boat wear. Keep inspecting.	Possible issue or negotiation point. Ask more questions or get it inspected before money changes hands.	Expensive or risky problem. Walk away unless you already know the repair cost.

The rule before you start

Do not inspect the boat you hope it is. Inspect the boat in front of you. If the seller is rushing you, if the paperwork is vague, or if something feels off -- slow down. Good boats do not need pressure tactics.

BEFORE YOU GO**5 minutes from your couch**

Before you spend time and fuel going to see a boat, ask these questions by text. A good seller will answer them without drama.

Copy and paste these 10 questions

- **Can you send a photo of the HIN on the transom?** (12 digits stamped on the transom -- look it up before you leave.)
- **Do you have a bill of sale or proof of ownership?**
- **Does the boat have a Pleasure Craft Licence (PCL) number?**
- **Do you have maintenance records?** On any boat over 5 years old, this matters. No records on an older boat means you're assuming the worst.
- **Can you send a cold-start video?** Cold start, not a warm idle. A seller who won't do this has a reason.
- **When was it last in the water?** A boat that's been sitting for two seasons needs extra scrutiny.
- **When was the impeller or water pump last serviced?**
- **Has the lower-unit gear oil ever shown water?**
- **Are there any soft spots in the floor or transom?**
- **Are there any known issues you'd want to know about if you were buying it?** (The most useful question on the list.)

Red flags before you leave

If any of these come up in the pre-trip conversation, that tells you something:

- Seller won't send a HIN photo.
- Seller "doesn't have the paperwork handy."
- Boat is being sold for someone else, but the details are fuzzy. (A common cover for title problems.)
- Seller won't run the motor.
- Price is "only good if you come today."

Pressure is a red flag. Good boats do not need a countdown timer.

Sources: Transport Canada -- *Apply for or manage a Pleasure Craft Licence* (tc.canada.ca/en/marine-transportation/vessel-licensing-registration). Transport Canada -- *Creating and inscribing a hull serial number*.

WHAT TO BRING

Everything fits in a backpack

You don't need a full shop setup. You need enough to see clearly, take notes, and avoid guessing.

- **Phone with camera and flashlight** -- for HIN photos, evidence, and dark corners
- **Bright LED inspection light** -- for bilge areas, under consoles, inside lockers
- **Screwdriver handle or small plastic mallet** -- for light tapping on the hull
- **Magnet** -- run it along the hull; fiberglass won't attract it, but bondo or hidden steel repairs will
- **White paper towels** -- for checking gear oil colour and testing bilge water
- **Gloves** -- bilges are not clean
- **Tire pressure gauge** -- for the trailer
- **Notepad or notes app** -- write down every issue; you'll forget half on the drive home
- **A second person, if possible** -- see below

About compression testers

A compression tester is useful only if you know how to use it safely and consistently. A proper test involves pulling spark plugs, disabling ignition or fuel as appropriate, cranking the engine safely, and recording each cylinder the same way.

For most buyers, the better move is simple: ask the seller for compression numbers, ask who performed the test, and get the motor checked by a marine shop (HBW or otherwise) before money changes hands.

The second-person advantage

Bring someone with you if you can. One person watches the transom while the other trims the motor. One person checks trailer lights while the other sits in the tow vehicle. One person keeps asking practical questions while the other avoids getting swept up in the deal. **Used-boat buying gets emotional fast. A second set of eyes helps.**

MINUTES 0-5

First impression

Start before you touch anything. A boat usually tells you how it has been treated. Do the first lap quietly. Take photos before you start asking too many questions. Don't let the seller narrate you past the problems.

What to scan in the first 60 seconds

- **Cover and storage** -- torn cover, pooled water, mildew. Suggests neglect or long outdoor storage.
- **Bilge** -- standing water, fuel smell, heavy grime. Suggests leaks, fuel issues, poor maintenance.
- **Hardware** -- missing screws, broken latches, loose trim. Deferred repairs.
- **General condition** -- fresh paint, mismatched parts, rough repairs. Cosmetic work or hidden damage.
- **Seller behaviour** -- rushing, vague answers, excuses. Risk you can't inspect properly.

GREEN	YELLOW	RED
Normal dirt, minor scratches, honest wear.	Fresh paint, missing trim, vague maintenance history.	Fuel smell, standing water, seller refuses basic inspection.

If it's on a trailer

Look at the trailer first. Check tire sidewalls for dry rot (hairline cracking in the rubber). Find the DOT date code -- four digits on the sidewall, last two are the year. **Tires more than six years old are a liability on a boat trailer regardless of tread depth.** Check that safety chains are present and the winch strap isn't fraying.

MINUTES 5-15

Hull and transom

This is where bad boats get expensive. A motor can be priced. A trailer can be repaired. A rotten structure can turn a cheap boat into a full restoration project.

Tap test

Bring your knuckles or a screwdriver handle and tap the hull systematically. Solid fiberglass sounds sharp and hard. Delamination sounds dull and hollow. Work the bottom, the sides, and especially the transom in a grid. Don't just tap two spots and move on.

Transom check

Trim the motor partly up. Grab both sides of the motor mount and push and pull while someone watches the transom. **There should be zero flex.** Any movement means the transom core is rotted -- a four-to-five-figure repair, often more than the boat is worth. **Walk away.**

Chines, keel, and cracks

Get down and look at the keel and lower chines. These take the first damage in a grounding. Look for impact gouges, radiating cracks, or patches. Around through-bolted hardware (cleats, rod holders, ski tow points), look for spiderweb gelcoat cracks. Small surface cracks are common; cracks that penetrate the laminate indicate load stress and potential water intrusion.

Osmosis blisters

Look at the hull near the waterline. Clusters of small bubbles or pocks in the gelcoat? Poke one -- if it weeps brownish liquid with a sour smell, that's osmosis. Minor blistering can be addressed; extensive osmosis into the laminate is a significant repair job.

Walk the floor

Start at the transom and walk slowly toward the bow, pressing firmly with each step. **A solid floor doesn't move.** Soft spots mean the plywood sub-floor is saturated -- which often means the stringers below are compromised too. Stringer rot is a full restoration, not a repair.

GREEN	YELLOW	RED
Small cosmetic scratches, minor gelcoat chips, clean repairs.	Old repairs, localized cracks, small isolated soft spot.	Transom movement, widespread soft floor, major cracks, impact damage.

MINUTES 15-20

Interior and systems

Open everything. Hatches, lockers, battery compartments, livewells, storage boxes, helm access panels, and bilge covers all tell you something.

Under the cushions and at the helm

Lift every cushion, open every hatch, smell every locker. Standing water, mildew, and a fuel smell from the bilge are all worth noting. Turn on the battery switch and test everything: fuel gauge, tach, trim, bilge pump, livewell pump, nav lights, horn. Every broken item is either a negotiating point or a cost you're absorbing.

Check the wiring

Look under the dash and around the battery. **Good signs:**

- Clean wiring runs
- Fused circuits
- Proper battery terminals
- Marine-grade connectors
- Wires secured and protected from sharp edges

Bad signs:

- Twisted wires with tape
- Household wire nuts
- Loose battery cables
- Corrosion on terminals
- Random wires that lead nowhere
- Multiple accessories tied directly to the battery without proper protection

One broken item is normal. Five ignored problems tell a story. A full electrical rewire is a multi-day job. Shoddy wiring is also a fire hazard.

MINUTES 20-28

Outboard or sterndrive

A tired motor is fixable. A mystery motor is risky. The goal isn't to become a marine technician in eight minutes -- it's to separate normal used-motor wear from signs of neglect, overheating, water intrusion, or hidden damage.

Before it starts

Ask to have the cowl removed. A seller who won't take it off has something to hide. Check for: cowl condition, corrosion, cracked hoses, oil leaks, fuel leaks, loose wiring, damaged skeg, damaged prop, signs of fresh paint on the lower unit or powerhead. *Fresh paint isn't automatically bad -- fresh paint in the wrong place should make you ask what's underneath.*

When it runs

Ask for a cold start if possible. Watch and listen:

- Does it start reasonably?
- Does it idle smoothly?
- Is there a steady tell-tale water stream?
- Does trim and tilt work?
- Does it shift cleanly into forward and reverse?
- Is there excessive smoke after warm-up?
- Are there any alarms?
- Does the seller avoid running it under normal conditions?

Prop and lower unit

Inspect for bent blades, nicks, and signs of a spun hub. A spun hub means the rubber insert between the prop and shaft has failed -- the prop looks fine but won't transmit power. Ask the seller to drain a sample of lower-unit gear oil onto white paper towels. Fresh gear oil is translucent gold or green. **Milky, grey, or chocolate-brown oil means water intrusion** -- a failed seal or cracked housing. **Milky gear oil is a deal-breaker.**

Compression

Compression numbers tell you whether the cylinders are sealing consistently. Exact PSI varies by engine, gauge, procedure, and temperature -- **consistency matters more than any universal number.** As a general rule, outboard cylinders should be within about 10% of each other. If you don't own a tester or know how to use one safely, ask the seller for numbers and get a shop to verify before money changes hands.

GREEN

YELLOW

RED

Cold-starts cleanly, idles smooth, steady tell-tale, gear oil clean.	Old service records, slight smoke, weak tell-tale, uncertain compression.	Won't cold-start, milky gear oil, fresh paint hiding damage, refused inspection.
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Repower note: Found a solid hull with a tired outboard? That may be the boat worth saving. The hull is the hard part. A motor can be priced, planned, and replaced. If the structure is sound and the motor is the weak link, build a Mercury repower quote at mercuryrepower.ca and see whether the numbers make sense.

MINUTES 28-30

Trailer details

The trailer can ruin the deal too. A boat that looks affordable can get expensive fast if the trailer needs tires, bearings, bunks, wiring, lights, brakes, or structural repair before you can tow it safely.

What to check

- **Tires** -- tread, sidewalls, DOT date code. Tires older than six years are replacement candidates.
- **Spare tire** -- present and serviceable?
- **Wheel bearings / hubs** -- after a short tow, warm is fine; **hot** (can't keep your hand on it) means failing bearings.
- **Frame** -- surface rust is normal; rust that's eaten through the steel is not.
- **Bunk boards and carpet** -- rotted wood grinds into the hull.
- **Winch strap** -- check for fraying.
- **Safety chains and coupler** -- present, intact, properly sized.
- **Lights** -- plug them in and test brake lights, turn signals, running lights. Trailer wiring is usually a simple fix, but add it to the list.
- **Brakes (if equipped)** -- working?

GREEN	YELLOW	RED
Working lights, decent tires, solid bunks.	Older tires, surface rust, worn winch strap.	Rotten frame, failed lights, hot hubs, cracked tires, unsafe coupler.

Source: Tire Rack -- How Do I Determine The Age Of My Tires?

WALK AWAY IMMEDIATELY IF**Some findings aren't negotiating points****LEAVE THE LISTING IF...**

1. **The transom flexes** when you push and pull on the motor mount.
2. **The gear oil is milky or grey** -- water in the lower unit, likely needs a rebuild.
3. **The floor is soft anywhere** -- saturated stringers, major structural repair.
4. **The seller won't run the motor.** Excuses mean reasons.
5. **The seller refuses reasonable inspection steps** -- no cowl off, no gear oil sample, no compression numbers.
6. **No maintenance records on a 10+ year-old boat** -- you're assuming the worst.
7. **Fresh paint on the lower unit or powerhead** -- ask what's underneath.
8. **Compression is low or inconsistent**, or the seller refuses to provide or allow a proper test.
9. **Ownership documentation is unclear or missing**, or the HIN doesn't match the paperwork.
10. **The deal depends on you deciding right now.**

Repair reality

Use this table when you're deciding whether a problem is normal, negotiable, or a reason to leave.

USUALLY MANAGEABLE	NEEDS INSPECTION	OFTEN NOT WORTH IT
Prop repair	Old hull repairs	Rotten transom
Trailer lights	Weak tell-tale stream	Stringer rot
Battery replacement	No maintenance records	Unclear ownership
Minor upholstery	Localized soft spot	Major engine damage
Routine service	Uneven compression	Missing or altered HIN
Worn winch strap	Lower-unit oil concern	Seller refuses inspection

THE BOTTOM LINE**The question that decides everything**

Work through the walkaround in order. Take notes. Don't let the drive, the asking price, or the seller's enthusiasm override what your hands and eyes are telling you.

A 30-minute inspection won't catch everything, but it will catch the things that matter most. The deals that go sideways are almost always the ones where someone moved too fast to look carefully.

THE QUESTION TO ASK YOURSELF

**If you had to spend real money fixing this boat before using it,
would you still buy it?**

If the answer is no, don't let the asking price talk you into it.

FOUND A BOAT WITH A SOUND HULL BUT A TIRED MOTOR?

That's exactly what we repower. Build your Mercury quote at mercuryrepower.ca -- real prices, no runaround. Or book a service consult at hbw.wiki/service.

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FIELD CHECKLIST**Print this page. Take it with you.****Before you drive**

- Seller sent HIN photo
- Seller confirmed proof of ownership
- Seller confirmed Pleasure Craft Licence number (if applicable)
- Seller has maintenance records or explained why not
- Seller agreed to run the motor
- Seller sent cold-start video (if requested)
- Asking price still makes sense after known issues

Paperwork

- HIN matches paperwork
- Bill of sale or proof of ownership is clear
- Seller name matches ownership trail
- No vague "selling for a friend" story
- No pressure to skip paperwork

Hull and transom

- Keel and chines checked for impact damage
- Transom checked for movement (zero flex required)
- Floor walked end-to-end, no soft spots
- Hatches opened, bilge inspected
- Drain plug area inspected
- No major cracks or suspicious repairs

Interior and systems

- Bilge pump works
- Navigation lights work
- Horn works
- Gauges checked
- Battery terminals checked
- Wiring inspected (no household-grade splices)
- Seats and bases checked
- Storage compartments checked

Motor

- Cold start observed
- Idle smooth
- Tell-tale water stream steady
- Trim and tilt works
- Forward and reverse shift cleanly
- Prop and skeg checked
- Lower-unit gear oil condition checked or discussed
- Compression numbers reviewed or shop inspection planned

Trailer

- Tire tread + sidewalls + DOT date code checked
- Spare tire checked
- Lights / brake lights / turn signals work
- Winch strap and safety chains intact
- Bunks and frame inspected (no rotted wood, no rust-through)
- Hubs checked for heat after towing

Final decision

- **BUY** -- price reflects condition, problems are known and priced
- **INSPECT FURTHER** -- get a shop or surveyor to verify before committing
- **WALK AWAY** -- structural / paperwork / motor problem too big to absorb

Notes:
